AcademiaConnect – User Testing Results (Qualitative)

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Note on modifications from the submitted plan

The user testing plan was adapted due to prototype constraints. Sessions were dialogue-based and used on an in- progress vibe coded app prototype. Participants were asked to assume that the papers, matches, and resources shown were relevant to their research area. A post-test survey has been created to collect Likert-scale (1–5) responses, but quantitative results are not available yet because responses are still pending. Survey link: [here].

Key interactions and metrics tested

This round of testing focused on whether PhD users could understand AcademiaConnect's intent and make informed choices using the interface. Specifically, I examined these features:

- The Workspace flow, including comprehension of the Add Paper steps and interpretation of key actions in Writing Mode.
- The Connect feature, including the ability to select a peer match and identify what additional information would be needed before reaching out.
- Overall perceived utility and points of confusion across screens.

I probed users' decision rationales with prompts such as, "What do you think this button would do?" to assess whether labels and interactions matched user expectations.

User testers and method

Participants: 4 PhD students (3 in first year School of Education, 1 in 3rd year Finance program) and 1 MEITE program user. Recruitment was via peer/class networks. Sessions were ~15–25 minutes and conversational, using a think-aloud style while reviewing screens.

Evidence notes: One session was audio recorded, rest were conversational with me taking notes. Findings are based on my notes and post-session synthesis. Quotes are used when remembered verbatim; otherwise I have paraphrased the feedback.

App Features Tested For

1. **Add Paper:** Review Step 1 (Upload PDF) and describe expected Step 2 (Add Details) and Step 3 (Review & Save).

2. **Writing Mode:** Explain what this mode will help with, what can be improved, what the AI assistant would do; describe expected AI suggestions and control (accept/decline).
3. **Connect**: Choose one peer match to contact and explain decision factors; identify missing information and interaction expectations.
4. **Overall:** Purpose and relevance of the app for PhD students.

Key insights and evidence

1. **Strong perceived value and clarity of the overall concept**
   - Across users, the core idea was received positively as helpful for the PhD journey.
   - One user especially valued the collaboration and connection element and described the product as a "one-stop shop."
   - Evidence:
     - Participant 1: "Love the idea, seems very helpful and appropriate for the PhD journey."
     - Participant 2: "One-stop shop… easy to collaborate."
2. **My Library needed clearer meaning and action labels**
   - One user was confused whether My Library contained papers they had written versus papers they had saved or uploaded.
   - The View and Edit buttons were not self-explanatory without additional cues.
   - Evidence:
     - Participant 2 asked whether My Library is "papers that the user has written" and had questions about what View vs Edit do (paraphrase).
3. **Writing Mode AI support is compelling, but users want stronger transparency and linking**
   - Users liked the AI writing support and the idea of accepting or declining suggestions.
   - Users want to see how the AI connects uploaded papers with their own ideas and drafts.
   - Evidence:
     - Participant 4: "I like the AI option in writing and that I can accept or decline the suggestion." This participant also wanted to see how AI connects uploaded papers and ideas.
4. **Connect is valued, but missing interactions.**
   - Participant 5 said when clicked on message button, nothing happened
5. **Overall:**
   - All users described AcademiaConnect as useful and needed for PhD work.
   - One user clicked a message feature that did not open, indicating a gap between UI expectation and prototype interaction.
   - Users suggested signals such as collaboration intent and advanced filtering; one user suggested wellbeing/productivity tracking.

- A user recommended adding an option to add a paper link in Add Paper. I am still considering this option.
- A user liked that Recent Publications included both research and hobbies, noting it could build reading habits.
- A user also mentioned that in the writing mode there is not enough space to write, which made a lot of sense. To encourage people to write the writing canvas should be bigger.
- Evidence:
    - Participant 1 liked the ability to connect easily.
    - Participant 3: "Connect page seems very useful and needed…". They also noted that the message button did not open.

How these insights inform next steps

Based on the qualitative findings, the next iteration of the app prioritized clarity, trust, and consistent interactions before expanding scope:

- Clarity: I refined the 'My Library' labels. It now includes two options- 'Uploaded papers' and 'My notes & Drafts' so users immediately understand what content lives there and what View/Edit buttons do.
- Trust and transparency: In Writing Mode, I added easy to use AI suggestions option right on the top.
- Improving the 'Writing Mode': Given that writing mode is one of the main features of this app, I changed UX of this page. I adapted the left panel to reflect the writing mode needs, increased the writing canvas, and added 'More Tools' option
- Scope management: I treated wellbeing and productivity tracking as out of scope for this iteration because it extends beyond the app's core purpose and could function as a standalone product. To respond to the underlying need without expanding scope, I am exploring a lightweight alternative such as optional home-page insights or notifications (for example, basic progress updates or patterns in productive hours). Note: this idea I am still exploring and may not include in the final version.
- Data collection: I have deployed the post-test survey link and will report results once responses are received.